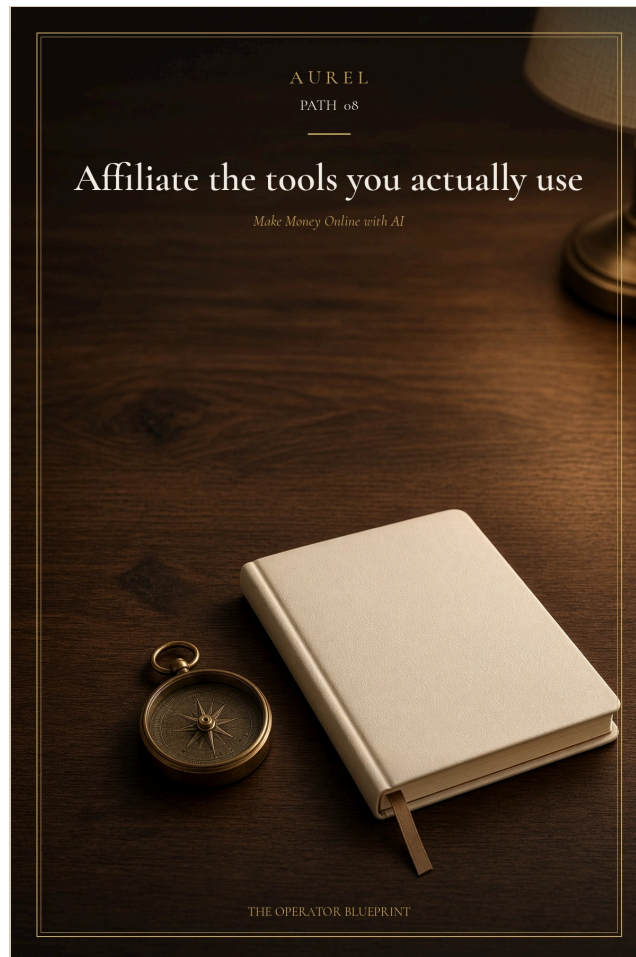




PATH 08

Affiliate the tools you actually use

The review must stand if the link is removed. That is the whole ethic, and the whole conversion trick.

17 minute read · 3,644 words

Who this is for

You already recommend models, hosts, editors, or shops. You can write why, not just drop a URL.

Time to first

14–45 days (cookie + trust lag)

Tools

First sale

One commission from a review a real person used.

Cash window

Varies; treat as a sidecar, not the engine

Leave this alone

Official partner programs, a simple page or newsletter, honest disclosure.

Twenty links in a thread. Tools you have never opened.

How this pays without rotting your name

Affiliate is monetization, not a traffic plan. If nobody reads you, the link does nothing. Short-form and the weekly letter bring the people. This path takes a cut when they buy a tool you would keep using if the commission died.

The review must stand if the link is removed. That is the whole ethic, and the whole conversion trick. Write as if tomorrow a lawyer strips every URL. What remains should still help a tired person decide. If what remains is empty cheer, you wrote an ad. Ads from strangers do not convert, and they do not age well next to your name.

Why honest beats a glowing list Write what broke. What you still use. Who should skip it. That piece outsells a glowing list because tired people can smell a list. They have been burned by “best 50” pages that were updated never and used never. One page, one tool, your stack, a date on it — that is the product.

What this is not It is not a coupon blog. It is not twenty links in a thread. It is not a tool you opened once on a free weekend. It is a sidecar on work you already do: a letter, a playbook, a package. Treat commissions as extra, not as the engine. If the engine is affiliate, you will start recommending whatever pays this month, and your name will follow the payout.

Who this is for — and who should skip it

This path fits if you already recommend models, hosts, editors, or shops, and you can write why, not just drop a URL. You need a real stack. You need a place to publish one page or one issue. You need the patience for cookie lag.

You are a fit if You pay for a tool with your own money. You have told a friend, in plain words, why you kept it. You are willing to put a disclosure at the top that you would want from that friend. You already have (or are building) a letter or a simple page where a review can live for a year.

Skip this path if You do not use anything you would recommend with the link ripped out. You want cash this week — cookies take 14–45 days, and some programs pay later than that. You like roundups of tools you have never opened. You will not update a page when the price changes. A dated lie is worse than no page.

If you have no readers yet, start the letter or the front door first. Affiliate does not create attention. It rides it.

The offer, named in one sentence

You are not selling the tool. You are publishing a review a real person can use, with a link underneath for the ones who decide to buy. The sentence: “I use [tool] for [job]. Here is who it is for, how long setup took, what I tried, what failed, and who should not buy. If you purchase through this link I may earn a cut. The review is the same either way.”

One tool, one page Do not build a “best 50 AI tools” page. That is a farm. One honest page per tool you love. If you use two things (a model and a host), that is two pages, written months apart if you need the time, each with its own disclosure and its own date.

What the reader gets even if they never click A decision. Setup time. A failure they can avoid. A skip rule. If they finish the page and choose a competitor, you still did the job. That is how the next review gets believed.

What ‘done’ looks like

Done is one commission from a review a real person used. Not a screenshot of a dashboard full of pending cookies. A human told you they bought because the page named the thing that was stuck, or you saw a conversion you can tie to that URL.

The page bar - Disclosure at the top, in words you would want from a friend - Link below the reasoning, not above it - Who it is for, setup time, what you tried, what failed, who should not buy - Your own stack. Screenshot your own dashboard if the program allows it. No fake screenshots. - A date. Updated when pricing or the product changes.

The money bar Treat it as a sidecar until the list is real. One commission is done for VI. A farm of fifty unpaid roundups is not a business. It is a hole.

How the money actually shows up

You do not set the product price. The program does. Your job is to pick tools you already use, join official partner programs, and accept that cash is lumpy.

Cookie and trust lag Time to first is 14–45 days because people read, wait, compare, then buy, and the cookie has to still be alive. Some programs pay on a schedule after that. If you need rent on Friday, this is the wrong path for Friday. Run a package. Let this ride along.

What “varies” means A host or a model can pay a cut of a month, a year, or a one-time seat. Do not build a spending plan on a number you saw in someone else’s screenshot. Count commissions after they clear. Until then, it is a maybe.

What you never do for a higher cut You never hide the disclosure. You never pretend you still use a tool you cancelled. You never stuff every paragraph with links. You never invent a claim the program bans (“guaranteed income,” “official partner of the year” when you are not). The extra click is not worth the name.

The first 72 hours

You are not launching a media company. You are joining two programs and writing one review.

Hours 1–8: programs and rules Join two official partner programs for tools you already use. Not four. Not a directory of “high paying.” Two you can screenshot from your own login. Read the trademark rules and the disclosure rules. Note what you may not say. Note whether screenshots of the dashboard are allowed. If a program wants you to hide the relationship, skip it.

Hours 9–24: write the review Structure: who it is for, setup time, what you tried, what failed, who should not buy. Disclosure at the top. Link below the reasoning, not above it. Date it. Use a failure you actually had — a setup that took three hours, a feature that sounded magic and was not, a price change that annoyed you. Then say why you stayed.

Hours 25–72: publish and tell the people who already asked Put it on a simple page or in the newsletter. Same disclosure you would want from a friend. Share it once with people who asked you about that tool last month. Once. Not a week of reminders. Then wait. Cookies do not clear because you refreshed the dashboard.

The path, step by step

Twelve steps. One tool until the page is good.

Step 1. Only tools in your actual stack If you would cancel it when the affiliate account dies, it does not belong on the page. Screenshot your own dashboard if allowed.

Step 2. Join official programs only No third-party link cloaks you do not understand. No “network” that will swap the vendor later. Read the rules.

Step 3. Pick one tool for review one A model you draft with, or a host you send with. Not both in one URL soup.

Step 4. Write the structure on paper before the pitch Who it is for. Setup time. What I tried. What failed. Who should not buy. If a section is empty, you do not know the tool yet. Use it another week.

Step 5. Disclose at the top Quiet honesty converts better than a hidden link. Use the line in the copy section. Do not bury it under a fold of adjectives.

Step 6. Put the link below the reasoning After the skip rule is a good place. Once, maybe twice. Not in every sentence.

Step 7. Date the page Month and year. A dated review is a trust machine. “Updated” without a date is a trick people know.

Step 8. Publish on a simple page or in the letter The letter is allowed to carry the review. The page is allowed to be ugly. Working beats a microsite.

Step 9. Share once where people already asked Last month’s DMs. The group you actually help. Not a spray of “best tool??” comments under strangers.

Step 10. Do not build a best-50 farm One honest page per tool you love. A second tool waits until the first page has been read by someone who is not you.

Step 11. Update when pricing or the product changes A weekend, twice a year, or when they move a button you described. Wrong prices rot faster than wrong adjectives.

Step 12. Treat commissions as a sidecar until the list is real Do not quit a package or pause the letter because a cookie might convert. Keep the engine. Let this ride.

Worked example: Riley's one honest review

Riley drafts client follow-ups in a paid model and sends a Tuesday letter from a paid host. People in the inbox kept asking which model. Riley did not drop a link in a reply. Riley wrote one page.

The disclosure, on top “I use this model for drafts. If you buy through this link I may earn a cut. The review is the same either way. I would keep paying for it if the program vanished tomorrow. Updated March.”

The review Who it is for: people who write the same kind of client note every week and are tired of restating the voice.
Not for people who need a model to invent a business.

Setup time: forty minutes to a project with instructions, three good examples, and a “never do this” list. Riley said the first evening was messy. That line mattered more than a feature table.

What they tried: recap emails, a landing draft, a joke post. The recap emails were the win. The joke post was embarrassing and got cut. What failed: asking it to “sound more human,” which made it sound like a brochure. The fix was pasting two real emails and saying “match these, do not improve my personality.”

Who should not buy: anyone who will paste the raw output to a client. Riley says that twice. The model drafts. The human sends.

The link sits after the skip rule. One link. No “top 10 models.” No fake dashboard. Riley's own project list, names blurred, because the program allows it.

What happened Riley shared the page once with six people who had asked last month, and once in the Tuesday letter, below a story about the joke post that failed. Two weeks later a commission cleared. A third person wrote to say they skipped the tool, which Riley counts as the page working. Month 2, the host changed a plan name. Riley updated the date and one paragraph. Still one tool. Still not a farm.

Copy you can paste

Keep the disclosure boring. Boring is trustworthy.

Disclosure at the top I use this. If you buy through this link I may earn a cut. The review is the same either way.

Longer disclosure (if the program wants more) I am a [program] partner. I pay for [tool] with my own money and use it for [job]. Affiliate links may earn me a commission. I do not get paid to hide problems. Last updated [month year].

Page title I use [tool] for [job] — who it is for, what failed, who should skip it.

Share to people who already asked You asked me about [tool] last month. I wrote the page I wanted to send you: setup time, what broke, who should not buy. Disclosure at the top. Link at the bottom if you still want it: [url].

Letter close (after a real story) I drafted this issue in [tool]. If you want the review, it is here. If you want next Tuesday, it still arrives with no click required.

What not to write “Best AI tool of the year!!!” Twenty links in a thread. “I made \$12,000 in a weekend.” Claims the program bans. A disclosure in gray eight-point under a hero button.

Week-by-week

This path is slow on purpose. Plan the wait so you do not sabotage it with a farm.

Week 1: two programs, one review Join two official programs you already use. Read the rules. Write one review with the structure above. Disclosure on top. Link below. Publish. Share once with people who asked.

Week 2: share it where people already asked If you have a letter, one issue can carry the story, then the link. If you do not, the page plus the personal notes is enough. Do not start review two.

Weeks 3–6: do the other paths Cookie and trust lag live here. Keep sending the letter. Keep the package. Check the partner dashboard once a week, not once an hour.

Month 2: update the review Price, product, or your use — if something changed, change the page and the date. If nothing changed, add one paragraph about a new job you actually ran through the tool. Treat commissions as a sidecar until the list is real.

Do not add nineteen more tools because week 4 was quiet. Quiet is normal.

The quality bar

The stripped-link test is the bar. Remove every URL. Read the page. If a careful person could still decide, you are done. If the page collapses into “it is great, click here,” write it again.

The friend test Would you forward this to a friend who asked in good faith, even if they used a different link? If you would be embarrassed, it is an ad.

The failure test If you cannot name something that broke, you have not used it long enough, or you are hiding. Setup time that was worse than the marketing page counts. A feature you turned off counts. “Nothing failed” is a glowing list in one sentence.

The skip test Name who should not buy. Riley’s “do not paste raw output to a client” is a skip rule and a quality rule. A review with no skip is a brochure.

The screenshot test Your dashboard, if allowed. Never a fake. Never someone else's crop with the URL bar missing in a suspicious way. If screenshots are banned, use words.

What to count

Count slow numbers. This path lies if you watch it daily.

Count these - Reviews published that would stand with the link removed. Target: one. - People who already asked, that you actually sent the page to. Six to ten is a real week 1. - Clicks, if the program shows them, without panicking at a quiet day. - Commissions that cleared, not pending. First cleared one is the milestone. - Updates per review per year. Zero updates and a price change on their site means your page is now wrong.

Ignore these for now Other people's disclosed income. Rankings of "best affiliate offers." How many tools you could join. A 50-tool content calendar. If you have clicks and no commissions after 45 days, read the review again. Often the link is above the reasoning (people bounce) or you recommended a plan nobody in your audience needs. Fix the page. Do not add a roundup.

Objections you will hear

"Affiliate is sleazy." Hidden affiliate is sleazy. A disclosure on top and a review that names failure is how people already recommend tools, with a cookie attached. If you are ashamed of the tool, do not join the program.

"I need traffic first." Yes. This is not a traffic plan. Build the letter or the door. Then the page has somewhere to live.

“Programs take too long to approve.” Some do. Use the wait to write the review without the link, then add the URL. Do not apply to twelve programs to soothe the wait.

“What if they buy and the cookie misses?” It happens. The review still did the job. Do not add five tracking scripts to squeeze a maybe. You will look like a farm.

“Can I round up five tools I kind of used?” No. That is the glowing list. One tool you love. Tired people can smell a list.

“The commission is small.” It is a sidecar. Small plus honest plus a list that already trusts you beats large plus a name you cannot reuse.

What this path feeds — and what it needs

Affiliate rides the other paths. It does not replace them.

What it fills A Tuesday issue can tell the story of what failed, then point to the review. A playbook can mention the model you used, with the same disclosure. A package can include “here is the tool I draft in; you do not have to buy it.” The cut is extra. The trust is the asset.

What it needs People. Official programs. One page. A stack you still pay for. It needs you to leave twenty-link threads alone. If the letter dies, this path dies with it. Keep the letter.

Mistakes that rot the name

Fake, cancelled, and stuffed Fake screenshots. They will be caught, and even if they are not, you will know. Recommending a tool

you cancelled. The page becomes a trap for people who trust you.

Stuffing every paragraph with links. That is how readers stop reading, and how some programs warn you.

Forgetting that some programs ban certain claims. Income promises, trademark misuse, “official” language you were not given. Read the rules in week 1, not after a warning.

The farm Twenty links in a thread. Tools you have never opened. A best-50 farm. Hiding the disclosure. Dating the page “updated” without a month. Those are the same mistake: you optimized for a click instead of a decision.

Also: building this before you have a place people already look. A perfect review in a forest is still a forest.

Tools (official, few, used)

Official partner programs, a simple page or newsletter, honest disclosure. That is the stack.

Official partner programs Join from the vendor’s own site. Two to start, both in your actual stack: a model, a host, an editor, a shop you already pay. Read trademark and disclosure rules before you write a headline.

A simple page or newsletter The letter you already send is enough. A single page with a date is enough. You do not need a review site template with 40 comparison tables.

Honest disclosure Plain sentences at the top. Not a legal poem. Not a tiny footnote. The same words you would want from a friend.

Leave link-in-bio mazes of twenty tools, unofficial coupon extensions, and any program that asks you to hide the relationship. If they are shy, you should be too — all the way out the door.

Checklist

Tick this before you add a second tool.

Before you publish - Tool is in your actual stack; you would keep paying without the program - Official partner account, rules read - Disclosure written at the top - Structure complete: who it is for, setup time, what you tried, what failed, who should not buy - Link below the reasoning - Screenshot is yours, or no screenshot if banned - Date on the page - No banned claims

First 72 hours - One review, not a roundup - Shared once with people who already asked - Letter issue optional, still one link

Ongoing - Update when price or product changes - Commissions counted when they clear - Sidecar, not the engine - Still no best-50 page

FAQ

Can I join a program for a tool I used once? No. Use it until you can fill the failure section without inventing. Once is a first date. A review is a relationship.

Do I have to say “affiliate” in the first line? Say you may earn a cut if they buy through the link, and that the review does not change. That is the honesty. Use the word “affiliate” if the program or the law you are under wants it. Quiet and early beats clever and late.

Newsletter or a page? Either. Riley did a page and mentioned it in the letter. If you only have the letter, the issue can be the review. Keep the disclosure at the top of that issue.

How many links on the page? One primary. A second if there is a cheaper plan you actually think they should consider. Not a forest.

What if the program rejects me? Write the review anyway without a link, or pick the second tool you already use. Rejection is not a prompt to join a shady network.

Can I use AI to write the review? You can outline. You still have to add the scar: setup time, what failed, who should skip it. A model will write a glowing list. That is the thing we are not doing.

When do I add a second review? After someone who is not you used the first one, and you have updated it once. Then one more tool from the stack. Still not fifty.

Is this enough to live on? Treat it as a sidecar. Some months will surprise you. Do not schedule rent on a surprise.

What if my audience asks for a tool I hate? Tell them you do not use it. No link. Your skip rule is allowed to be the whole email.

The vendor changed pricing and my page is wrong. Update this week. Change the date. A dated correction builds more trust than a perfect first draft you abandoned.